

DESERT WILDLIFE



THE DRIEST PLACES ON EARTH are known as deserts. Food is scarce, and there is little shelter from the sun and wind. Deserts are among the most inhospitable of all places in which to live.

In spite of this, many remarkable animals survive and even thrive in these hostile surroundings. Birds, mammals, insects, arachnids, amphibians, and reptiles are all represented, together with some equally remarkable plants.

Sahara

Stretching across North Africa, the Sahara is the greatest of all deserts. It is a vast wilderness of sand and rock, with only scattered palms and bushes to offer shade from the searing daytime sun. Most of the animals that live there find shelter under rocks or in burrows.



Oases

Oases provide reliable sources of drinking water for wildlife in the desert. They form in the few places where springs bubble up from underground, or where rainwater from neighbouring mountains collects in hollows.

Birds

Though some desert-dwelling doves and finches forage for seeds, the most well-known birds of arid lands are predators. They probe vegetation and scour the ground for prey, obtaining all the moisture they need from the bodies of their victims.



Gila woodpecker

The Gila woodpecker forages for insects in the deserts of Mexico and the USA. Typically, it hammers out nest-holes in the stems of large cacti.



Roadrunner

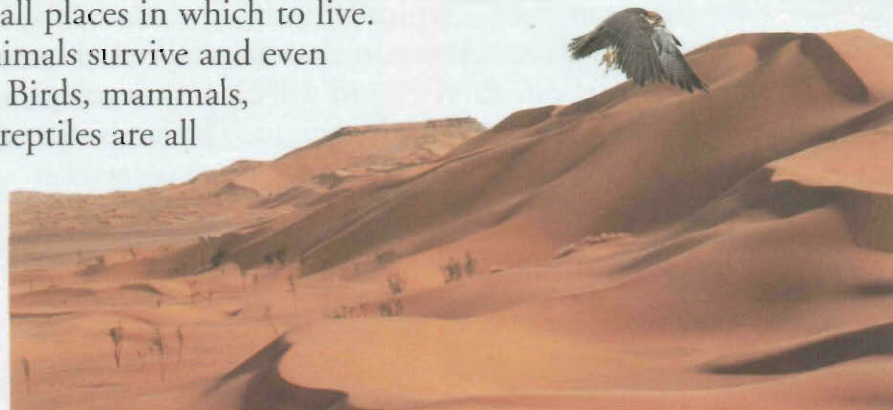
Roadrunners seldom fly, but they are extremely fast, agile runners. They often prey on desert snakes, which they subdue with a series of lethal stabs from their sharp beaks.



Lanner falcon

This darting bird of prey nests among rocks and cliffs in the Sahara. It hunts small birds, which it chases and snatches in mid-air or on the ground. It also preys on smaller animals, such as gerbils, lizards, and locusts.

Falcons can spot prey from a great height.



Deserts

Many different types of desert exist in different parts of the world. Some are mountainous and rocky; others are pebbly or full of sand dunes. Some become baking hot by day; others have bitterly cold winters.



Pale-coloured fur reflects heat.

Dwarf hamster

Only about 8.5 cm (3.3 in) long, this hamster lives in the deserts of Mongolia, Siberia, and China. It has thick fur, which helps to keep it warm in the bitterly cold winters.

Long, bushy tail can be curled around the body to keep it warm during the night.



Large erect ears help the fox to hear the slightest sound of prey and tell from where it is coming.

Fennec fox

The fennec fox is small with large pointed ears. The large size of the ears helps the fox lose excess heat from its body during the heat of the day. The fox has dense fur, which keeps it warm on cold nights.



Red kangaroo

In Australian deserts, red kangaroos browse on bushes. They produce dry dung as a way of saving moisture, but still make regular trips to waterholes to replace moisture lost through sweating.



Kalahari ground squirrel

These burrowing rodents eat seeds and other plant material in the Kalahari Desert of Africa. During the day, they hold their bushy tails over their bodies for shade.

Bactrian camel

Camels are perfectly adapted for life in deserts. They can roam about for days without drinking or sweating. The two humps of the Bactrian camel act as fat reserves, off which the animal can live. The shaggy coat protects the camel during the cold winters in Asia's Gobi Desert.

Humps flop over when the fat is depleted.



Long fur covers the upper surface of the feet.